INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

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Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

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‘Neither Silent Nor Invisible’: Anti-poverty Communication in the San Francisco Bay Area

Dorothy Kidd and Bernadette Barker-Plummer

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Abstract

The communication practices of three US anti-poverty groups in the San Francisco Bay Area—Coalition on Homelessness, Poor News Network, and Media Alliance—are discussed whose communication strategies work for the recognition and rights of low-income and homeless people, and for policies to better redistribute economic and communications resources. In the wake of media closures in the local public sphere, and major restructuring of social welfare programmes, these groups’ creative and engaged communication strategies empower poor people and support the building of counter-public spheres working in interaction with, and as alternatives to, dominant media spheres.

Keywords

Civil society, Governance and public policy, Social sector, Rights, North America

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> *I just want to say that although we are at the lowest link of our economy and our society, we still have the right to be informed. Even though we don't make enough money with our meager jobs to pay the Internet fees and the costs of computers, our truth should still be heard; and our truth is asking the scientists and all the righteous people of this world, why it is that poor people exist? Our answers are not what the books tell us, but the truth that we publish at POOR Magazine. We are working people who are contributing to the economic prosperity of this country and we have a right to be heard!* (Gloria Esteva 2008)

In 2003, the Bellagio Symposium on Media, Freedom, and Poverty in Developing Countries highlighted the link between media and poverty reduction (Deane 2005: 190–192). The final declaration stated, in part, that people living in poverty face numerous 'obstacles to achieving freedom of expression and access to the media', which if not remedied can 'undermine the capacity of the poor to participate in democratic processes ... and lead to disaffection with the political process resulting in apathy or violence'. The participating social advocates reached consensus on 15 action points, among which were the support for more participatory media access for the 'disadvantaged', training of journalists in poverty-related issues, encouragement of community media and public-service broadcasting mandates addressing poverty, and more research on the implications of current media trends for poverty reduction. The Bellagio Declaration, according to James Deane, one of the conference conveners, was part of a much-needed process to 'reverse the remorseless erosion of the public sphere caused by the growing disinterest of the media in public interest issues' .[1]

The Bellagio conference's focus on the importance of media and communications in eradicating poverty, and its goal of developing strategies to encourage better public communication by and about poor people, are the topics of this paper. In particular, we discuss how anti-poverty advocates in the San Francisco Bay Area are developing communication and media practices that advocate for the recognition and rights of low-income and homeless people. We describe and analyse the communication practices of a small network of grassroots groups—the Coalition on Homelessness, The Poor News Network, and Media Alliance[2] —that have been involved in anti-poverty communication and media work for several years, asking whether and how their autonomous communication practices have improved poor peoples' public voice (the politics of recognition) or impacted urban poverty policies (the politics of redistribution).[3]

The erosion of the public sphere, noted by Deane (2005), is very evident in the USA, and in the San Francisco Bay Area where we live and work. An increasingly conglomerated and profit driven news industry has reduced coverage of social issues, decreased the diversity of view points in the news, and cut local news staff, replacing community news with syndicated national content (Bagdikian 2004; Kidd 2005; McChesney 2004). However, it is critical to note

[1] According to Deane (2005: 182-185), the decline in the media's facilitation of the public debate necessary for democratic decision making and poverty reduction is due to a number of global factors, such as the increase in corporate media concentration and advertising-driven media, the continuing dominance of 'Northern-based' news providers, and media censorship in the wake of the terrorist attack on the World Trade Center on 9 September 2001.

[2] Dorothy Kidd has participated as a member of Media Alliance since 1999, and currently serves on the Board of Directors.

[3] This paper is part of a larger research project investigating the communication strategies of social justice groups that intervene in the public sphere, tracking the outcome of their communications in media representation and policy (see Barker-Plummer and Kidd 2009, forthcoming).

that this erosion of the commercial public sphere exists alongside, and is being countered by, the strategic communication and media practices of social-change groups. Indeed, some of the solutions proposed by the Bellagio conference—such as training poverty journalists and increasing autonomous communication—are already emergent in the anti-poverty groups that we have studied. These few groups cannot fully represent all others, of course, and the San Francisco Bay Area has its own unique political culture, but by analysing the experiences of these groups, we hope to illuminate some important issues in anti-poverty communication more generally.

Communication, public sphere(s), and social change

The importance of communication practices to social-change movements is both obvious and complex. From the collective articulation of new identities by emergent social groups, to the publicising of political interests and claims through commercial and alternative media, to the creation of shared 'public' issues and agendas, interpersonal, group, and mass communication processes intersect with and sustain (or undermine) social change (Barker-Plummer 1995). But how do specific communication practices play out in any particular social mobilisation? And which kinds of communication practices are most associated with particular goals or outcomes? For example, what kinds of communication strategies are most likely to succeed in producing recognition for poor peoples' perspectives and rights? What kinds of strategies are effective in impacting poverty policies and the treatment of poor people?

Habermas (1989) has provided the concept of the public sphere to conceptualise the 'civic' space in democratic societies in which people come together to discuss public issues, ideally in a context free from market or state pressures. Though Habermas's conception of the 'ideal' public sphere has been roundly criticised, and his ideal sphere does not exist anywhere, the utility of the concept remains in its tying together of *citizen* communicative practices with healthy democratic life. Unless there is wide access to public debate, notes Habermas, in which all kinds of groups are able to articulate and make claims on behalf of their interests, then democracy will fail.

Fraser (1993) has offered an especially useful intervention in public-sphere debates by insisting that the Habermasian concept of 'the' public sphere must give way to a more multiple perspective of overlapping and contentious spheres, some of which are associated with dominant representative power (policy making and resource distribution) and others which play a different, alternative democratic role. In this project, we particularly draw on Fraser's conceptualisation of *subaltern counter-public spheres* in which 'members of subordinated groups invent and circulate counter-discourses, which in turn permit them to formulate oppositional interpretations of their identities, interests and needs' (Fraser 1993: 14). Fraser's model of multiple spheres not only usefully complicates the idea of a single public sphere, but it also allows for (and ties together) two sometimes opposing concepts of justice—the 'politics of recognition' (or identity politics), in which groups come together to create shared identity, articulate group interests, and demand recognition, and the 'politics of redistribution', in which claims to resources are made (Fraser and Honneth 2003: 1–5). These two political frameworks, one of which centres on identity factors and the other on resources, have often been separated in political analysis. In Fraser's conceptualisation of public spheres (also elaborated

by others, such as Williams 2000 and Sreberny 2005), the politics of recognition and voice are inseparable from, and a step towards, resource claims. Annabelle Sreberny (2005: 246–247) has added the 'politics of rights' to the repertoire of alternative communication practices.

The concept of counter-public spheres is an especially useful one when engaging with the political activities of marginalised or under-represented groups. For these groups, such as poor, homeless people, or immigrants, for whom easy access to the dominant public spheres (commercial media, local government meetings, academia, and so on) is difficult, the ability to come together and create alternative spaces is extremely important. Whether these alternative (counter-public) spheres exist as a precursor to engagement with dominant spheres (as Fraser suggests) or they have meaning and value in and of themselves (Sreberny 2005), the communicative practices that create and sustain these alternative spheres—for example, non-formal education, autonomous newspapers and websites, networks, media strategies—are critical components in understanding social change processes. As our case studies demonstrate, for anti-poverty groups, and especially for homeless people, who have been marginalised and labelled as deviant, the ability to come together and create a shared (and humane) identity and to articulate group interests and rights is a critical step in making redistributive claims in the dominant public spheres.

The Bay Area media context: commercial and community media

The commercial media sphere, in which these anti-poverty groups are working, has noticeably contracted in recent years. The majority of 'local' newspapers, broadcast radio, television, cable, and web services are now owned by national chains, or by transnational conglomerates. This has profoundly affected local programming, cutting off local news media's historical connection to local communities. Most content is now much more market driven, with an increase in entertainment, sports, and lifestyle news, packaged for evermore specific niches of consumers. This closure of space for community politics has affected the ability of many local groups to be heard at all, and for others it has increased the cost and time to produce news access (Barker-Plummer and Kidd 2009, forthcoming). In particular, groups working to reduce poverty, or groups representing 'people of colour'[4] or non-English speakers have found their (always limited) access to commercial media even more restricted as stations serving these communities have been bought out and reformatted as part of the drive to increase profit. For example, Clear Channel Radio's purchase of African-American and Spanish language owned and operated radio stations eliminated much of the local news, public affairs, and music designed and produced by and for these communities. When NBC-TV purchased Telemundo, the second-largest Spanish language television service, they cut news production entirely at KSTS-TV in San Jose, replacing it with a newscast from Fort Worth, Texas.

Cuts in local news staffing have limited news coverage of these communities even more. Mujeres Unidas, for example, a grassroots organisation of Latina immigrant women, reports that the situation is worse than ever, that reporters 'never come around' any more. Instead, reports about marginalised groups consistently misrepresent them. The Youth Media Council, for example, found an over-reportage of stories linking 'youth of colour'[4] to crime, and an absence of any attention to social issues defined by the youth themselves or responsive to

[4] 'People of colour' is a term used in California, where there is no longer any one group in the majority.

their perspectives (Youth Media Council 2002). Anti-poverty groups, which directly challenge commercial media logic, encounter additional constraints. By advocating for affordable housing, for example, the Coalition on Homelessness and the San Francisco Tenants Union face the additional, political hurdle of engaging with media whose advertising revenues are under written each week by the real-estate industry, which has very different interests in Bay Area housing policies.

Besides commercial media, the San Francisco Bay Area has a rich mix of alternative community-based media, which have often served as a resource for community politics. The Pacifica Radio flagship, KPFA-FM (begun in Berkeley in the late 1940s), several other community radio stations, and four Public Broadcasting Service (PBS) television stations serve the region, as does the *San Francisco Bay Guardian*, one of the oldest independent weekly newspapers in the USA. Since 2001, the Indy Media Center (IMC) has operated two open-publishing news sites, and a small but significant set of locally-oriented 'zines' and blogs has emerged more recently. Despite cuts to Latino- and African-American-owned commercial media, there are still a handful of 'locally-oriented' media outlets serving these sizable communities, as well as the Asian-American and lesbian, gay, and transgender communities. As access to commercial outlets shrinks, social-change groups tum more to these independent media sources.

The policy context: housing and anti-poverty policy

Although San Francisco is one of the wealthiest cities in the USA, when living costs are factored in, only New York City and Washington, DC have a higher percentage of people living in poverty. An estimated 8,000–15,000 people are living without permanent homes; rental housing is costly, and home ownership is outside the reach of all but the wealthiest. Much of the problem is embedded in recent history. As part of the neo-liberal turn of the 1980s, the Reagan Administration radically restructured the national government, making major cuts to national social programmes, including affordable housing, healthcare, and education; and simultaneously introduced an ideological paradigm that shifted the responsibility for poverty reduction away from the national government towards state and municipal governments, private providers, and individual families. The Clinton Administration continued this policy, ending a decades-long policy of national entitlement to welfare (Schram 2005: 5).

Although the City of San Francisco has often bucked the national trend by supporting more liberal social policies in principle, most mayors have encouraged gentrification. The rapid increase in upscale commercial, residential, and recreational developments, with corresponding decreases in affordable housing, reached its zenith in the late 1990s, when the influx of wealthy professionals from nearby Silicon Valley helped inflate rent and property prices. Thousands of working- and middle-class people, and dozens of social and cultural organisations, and NGOs, including Media Alliance, were forced to leave the city to find cheaper accommodation. Latino and African-American communities were affected the most; for example, between 1995 and 2000, San Francisco lost more of its black population than 18 other major US cities (Schulz 2008: 15). The latest financial crisis in the global housing market has only exacerbated the housing affordability crisis.

Over time, the city's social-welfare policies have also begun to reflect the national neo-liberal discourse. Defined in the 1960s and 1970s as conditions that could and should be eradicated through national intervention, poverty and homelessness are now more often described as the consequences of bad individual choices. The changing meaning given to 'quality oflife' reflects this paradigm shift. Initially identified with the national programme of civic renewal established after the urban riots of the late 1960s, Mayor Giuliani of New York reframed the concept in the 1980s in the interests of business- and professional-class people, and the New York City Police stepped up prosecution of low-level crimes, such as camping in public parks, public intoxication, graffiti, and panhandling ('aggressive' begging). Justified by the 'broken windows' theory, which argued that minor signs of urban decay would lead to bigger crimes, San Francisco Police adopted this same approach soon after. During the 1990s, as affordable housing stocks were reduced, successive civic administrations twinned the development of permanent 'shelters' or 'homeless services' with the criminalisation of homeless people through the prosecution of so-called 'quality of life' crimes, small misdemeanours such as panhandling, public urination, and graffiti. By 2006, for example, 31,230 'quality of life' citations had been issued in a two-and-a-half-year period. Although 80 per cent of the citations were dismissed, the effect was to further marginalise very poor people, and make it difficult for anyone convicted to ever find permanent housing (Shaw 2008).

Coalition on Homelessness

A group of homeless people and social-service workers formed the Coalition on Homelessness (CoH) in 1987, in response to the Reagan Government's first round of social service cuts and criminalisation of homeless people. The Coalition's website outlines the complexity of their mission: to 'foster the active participation of homeless and low-income San Francisco residents and front-line staff in the struggle for economic and social justice; ... to defend homeless and low-income people from attacks on their rights and their persons, while advocating for permanent solutions to homelessness that take into account not only poverty's devastating effects, but also its root causes' (Coalition on Homelessness 2008). CoH combines what Fraser and other theorists call the *politics of recognition* and of *redistribution*, common to counter-public spheres: needing to defend their interests and identities from attack by the dominant media, and governmental institutions, the Coalition created social spaces to regroup, share common experiences, formulate analyses of the problems confronting them, and strategise about ways to mobilise. The Coalition also utilises the discourse of human *rights* to protect homeless people against police harassment, against hate crimes committed against them, and more recently, for greater services for undocumented immigrants.

Communications are key to CoH's politics, and the Coalition combines horizontal communication among homeless and low-income people, social-service workers, and other allies, with vertical communication with City Hall administrators and politicians, and the media. They constantly provide homeless people and allies with updated information about housing, welfare, and policing services. Coalition staff also devote significant amounts of staff time and resources to strategic communications with the mainstream media. According to Chance Martin, once homeless himself, and a long-time editor of the CoH newspaper, the *Streetsheet*, the Coalition's objective is to establish itself as the 'authority on homelessness' (Martin 2004).

They train poor people to act as media spokespersons, including how to pitch and frame stories for the mainstream media; and have forged some good relationships with individual media workers in one or two commercial radio and TV outlets, the Spanish language news media, and the alternative and independent media.

However, the Coalition has had a particularly difficult time getting positive coverage in the last surviving major daily newspaper, the *San Francisco Chronicle*. Martin suggests that the *Chronicle* uses a formulaic frame, in which homeless people are discounted, either as migrants taking advantage of San Francisco's largesse, or as criminals. When the homeless are inter viewed, they are usually presented in such a way that they confirm the frame, and are seldom consulted for their insights. The Coalition is often quoted, but usually featured as the 'dissident voice'. A national study by Fairness and Accuracy in Reporting (FAIR) confirms Martin's observations (deMause and Rendall 2007). FAIR found that poor people are seldom consulted for their expertise on the causes of or solutions to poverty in national network news; instead, those who are represented tend to reinforce a frame that clearly separates those who are 'deserving' from those who are not.

Martin argues that the *Chronicle*'s financial ties to real-estate advertising limits its capacity to operate as a neutral sphere. This led to CoH's creation of its own newspaper, the Streetsheet:

> *You're not going to have a critical discussion of local, state or federal housing policy in the* Chronicle*, because the* Chronicle *isn't making money selling newspapers to the public; the* Chronicle *is making their money by delivering an advertising audience. Their number one source of advertising revenue is the real-estate industry. You're not going to get an impartial examination of anything there ... that really led us to push the* Streetsheet *to the forefront of our public education efforts because we couldn't get our message in tra ditional media without it being messed up.* (Martin 2004)

Streetsheet is a monthly tabloid, with news about issues of affordable housing, living wage employment, accessible healthcare, and educational opportunities, plus updates on public events and political demonstrations, as well as commentary, photos, and poetry. One of the first members of the North American Street Newspaper Association (NASNA), an organisation founded in 1996, it has since joined the International Network of Street Papers (INSP). As part of these two networks, *Streetsheet* identifies poverty as a global social problem, in which poor people's solidarity is central. In common with all street papers, *Streetsheet*' s revenue funds services for homeless people and poor communities, and low-income people make a little money selling the paper. But *Streetsheet* is much more than an income-generating scheme; it is a 'political and social tool for marginalized people to gain power in society by claiming a space to be heard' (Mailloux-Béïque 2005: 91 92).

Streetsheet provides a regular meeting space for homeless and poor people to establish mutual *recognition*, develop and share their own forms of knowledge, and *represent themselves* by contributing articles, stories, and photos. The vendors, who sell primarily to downtown professionals and political allies, 'occupy visible social spaces ... making the paper accessible and linked to the social actors who have produced it', challenging their stigmatisation and exclusion (Mailloux-Béïque 2005: 97). Further, the newspaper counters the power of experts to monopolise definitions of problems and remedies, giving poor people's voices deserved legitimacy and authority (Mailloux-Béïque 2005; Williams 2000).

As high housing costs have forced many tenants, artists, and social-justice organisations out of San Francisco, and the base of the Coalition's support has narrowed, it has become

more vulnerable to marginalisation by the commercial media and City Hall (Clarke 2008; Shaw 2008). Their decision to operate for and with poor people, and especially to refuse government funding, has meant a constant balancing act. Martin has noted a 'real polarisation around homeless issues' in recent years, leading to drop-offs in funding, and forcing the Coalition to drastically cut staff and services.

The Coalition, however, remains an important counter-public sphere, with a significant impact on public policy. Using grassroots organising based on the participation of homeless people and frontline staff, and developing coalitions with other anti-poverty groups, tenants' organisations, and faith-based social-justice groups, they have helped defeat many public measures against poor people and tenants in San Francisco and the state of California. And, by insisting on framing housing as a systemic and national problem, housing as a *collective* need, and homelessness as a *human-rights* abuse, CoH continues to represent an alternative discursive frame to the prevailing neo-liberal arguments. The Coalition has also initiated human-rights-styled campaigns, taking up the legal defences of those prosecuted for 'quality of life' crimes, pressurising the City to investigate assaults against poor people as hate crimes, lobbying for improvements in the housing shelters, as well as language services and support of immigrants. This commitment to universal values and inclusion of all reflects a respect for individual differences among life experiences, while fundamentally challenging the daily stigmatisation of homeless people and the 'structured differentiation which renders some groups unequal and/or excluded' (Williams 2000: 350).

Raising Our Voices-Media Alliance

Media Alliance is one of the oldest membership-based media activist organisations in the USA. Started by radical journalists in 1976, their initial goal was 'system change from within the media field—reforming corporate journalism, through defending media workers' rights, critiquing "bad" journalism and celebrating the "good", and training aspiring journalists' (Hackett and Carroll 2006: 108). In the late 1990s, Media Alliance shifted its remit, as its membership widened to include alternative media makers and social-justice groups who were creating their own media as part of counter-public spheres. As part of this new direction, Media Alliance began to train social-justice advocates to garner better representation in both alternative and mainstream media, and develop social-justice-oriented media (Hackett and Carrol 2006: 106).

In 2000, partly inspired by the first Seattle Indymedia Center *(IMC)*, Media Alliance convened a meeting of social advocacy and alternative media makers interested in collaboratively using the Internet to organise, educate, and intervene more effectively in public debates. However, rather than follow the IMC event-based model, which was directed principally by young media makers, the Alliance decided to focus on the most pressing issues facing social advocacy groups in the Bay Area. They selected housing as the Number 1 social crisis, an issue that affected every organisation and individual in the room. Using their own content and media expertise, they produced a website and other materials on the theme of the worst public and private landlords in the Bay Area. The project brought together activists from the Coalition on Homelessness, the San Francisco Tenants Union, Poor News Network, alterna-

tive media journalists, and trainees from the Media Alliance programme called Raising Our Voices (ROV).

ROV's purpose was to influence the public debate by providing trained journalists, photographers, and designers who could contribute to corporate, alternative, and social-justice media. According to Ben Jesse Clarke, they wanted

> *to take people who had the experience of being homeless, who knew intimately the neighbourhoods and the problems of poverty, and train them to interview and articulate the broader problems in their community.* (Clarke 2008)

Several people have graduated from the programme and gone on to contribute to Bay Area media, including Chance Martin, one-time editor of *Streetsheet.* Not unlike the IMC, and the contemporary movement of citizen journalists, ROV did not separate journalism and advocacy. 'First off, advocacy journalism was taught as the core of the curriculum. There wasn't any notion of teaching people corporate journalism. It was to teach them how to advocate for their communities using the media' (Clarke 2008). In addition, some students also became better advocates in other forums, as public speakers 'who could elaborate all the ways that federal housing policy is destroying their communities, in an articulate and intelligent manner, and then also write an article' (Clarke 2008).

In many ways, ROV operated like a temporary counter-public sphere. The organisers took great care to build a social space for groups to gather together, identify and share experiences:

> *The reality of broken communities like the Tenderloin ... was that social fragmentation and isolation were leading causes of people's addictions and inabilities to access the resources that they would need to make things work better. So we had pizza every night so people could eat together. We had social activities and then we developed a poetry and performance track of the classes. We had performance and gatherings and speak outs that were basically places where people were living their lives, and they weren't necessarily trying to reach a bigger audience, they were celebrating their own lives and their own communities. And then when we built up the steam, we built up a little road show that we tried to get to larger venues where a bigger audience could actually experi ence the fruits of people's labour.* (Clarke 2008)

These occasions were examples of the politics of *recognition*, in which previously excluded groups/identities 'reject the systematic disrespect or misrecognition' of their 'culture or way of life, [and] the dignity of their status as persons' (Williams 2000: 340).

Raising our Voices participants and staff also intervened in the wider public sphere around issues of *redistribution* of public resources. Their curriculum of community analysis, community practice, and grassroots expression helped forge a 'critical mass that could communicate, could do information sharing and education, and write stories about political issues', such as housing and welfare policy (Clarke 2008). The teachers, students, and Media Alliance staff and members also actively supported the campaigns and initiatives of anti-poverty organisations, such as the Coalition for Homelessness and Poor News. They also helped challenge the lack of representation of poorer and historically marginalised communities by San Francisco Bay media outlets; speaking out, for example, against Clear Channel's closure of a public-affairs programme for youth, and against the further reduction of public space in the media resulting from more corporate concentration of ownership (Kidd 2005).

Raising Our Voices ran from the late 1990s to 2004, when Media Alliance was no longer able to secure funding for the project. Some of the graduates and the trainers continue to

support Media Alliance in their work with anti-poverty journalists and media; in 2007, the organisation held a benefit for staff of one of the papers and initiated content analysis of the representation of poor people in the commercial media. In 2008, they ran Raising Our Voices III, a digital media training programme for immigrant women involved in community organisations, as well as mobilising immigrant and poor people's organisations to participate in public planning about local, state, and national communication policy.

Poor News Network

If the first two anti-poverty media projects came out of other concerns, first with homelessness, and then with media, Poor News Network is a standalone media project directed by poor people. Tiny Grey-Garcia and her mother Dee, two women who had been homeless, started their group in 1999, as part of a larger mobilisation against the housing crisis. During that period, the rising class of computer professionals from the boom in the computer and web industries of nearby Silicon Valley put added pressure on the inadequate housing stock in the city. Tenants, anti-poverty organisations, artists, non-profit organisations, and civic politicians mobilised against evictions and displacements, and against municipal zoning and other policy changes which would reduce affordable housing. The initial Poor News publication reflected the city's popular traditions of art in the service of politics. Designed as the first glossy literary magazine from poor people,

> *the idea was that it sits on a shelf in some yuppy enclave and people actually pick it up and read about someone who is dealing with poverty in the Third World, and the first world.* (Grey-Garcia 2005)

Since then, Poor News has grown to embrace some of the same goals as the Coalition on Homelessness and Raising Our Voices. They train people living in poverty to become journalists and media professionals, provide a communications space for their expression, and tactically use media to change social and political policy affecting poor people. Although critical of Clinton-era welfare retrenchment, their first training programme was funded through a welfare-to-work grant. Rather than equip poor people to fit into the waged labour market, or the existing commercial media system, they intended to produce a new kind of media, from the perspective of 'poverty scholars'. As Grey-Garcia said, 'other investigations do not give ownership, or power, or agency, to the people dealing with the stuff' (Grey-Garcia 2005).

Hampered by lack of long-term funding, Poor News nevertheless still provides training, which includes media studies, poverty studies, media literacy, Internet research and digital production, investigative journalism and production, and poetry and creative writing. Participating students have come from a variety of backgrounds: from low- and no-income to more privileged college students, youth who had been incarcerated, and recent immigrants. More recently, they initiated a training programme called 'Voces de Inmigrantes en Resistencia' (Voices of Immigrants in Resistance).

Like the other groups in our study, Poor News was seriously affected by the restructuring of corporate media in the Bay Area. Their once regular access to the daily press was lost when Hearst sold the *San Francisco Examiner,* bought the *Chronicle* and San Francisco became a one-newspaper town. With only occasional articles in the commercial media, they decided instead to develop their own network of media-oriented programmes. They no longer publish

the glossy magazine, but produce other print publications, DVDs, a website, a regular radio programme on Pacifica's KPFA, as well as supporting a performance troupe called the Welfare Queens. For a short time, they collaborated on a Community Newsroom Project, and now support and write for several community-operated independent news media.

The Poor News counter-public sphere, like the Coalition on Homelessness and Media Alliance's Raising Our Voices programme, combines the politics and practices of *representation, recognition, redistribution*, and *rights*. Their complex of media provides the expressive space to question their representation in dominant media, and public institutions develop, assemble, and share alternative 'scholarship' about the causes, experience, and necessary remedies for poverty; and in this active process, claim their voice and new forms of individual and social identity and political agency (Williams 2000: 346–349). Their representational work supports campaigns to defend the civil rights of poor people, including incarcerated youth, and most recently, undocumented immigrants; as well as larger mobilisations to redistribute resources. They also work with commercial media and other alternative media to circulate their creative work, and their ideas.

This linkage between dimensions is crucial for Grey-Garcia, for whom 'media organising', means using the media as the root of a political campaign. She notes, 'Media can be so harmful to low- and no-income communities, and it is therefore so vital to keep our truths out there ... We're not an island unto ourselves'.

Poor News also uses media tactically, creating short-term artistic media events to defend tenants and homeless people, and intervene in municipal debates about development in San Francisco and the neighbouring city of Oakland. For example, when the City of San Francisco announced a programme designed to move homeless people away from the periphery of the civic square, by limiting their use of shopping carts, Poor News created a set of 'Art Carts'. They then contacted all the English- and Spanish-language television channels to cover their demonstration. The next day, the Mayor cancelled the plan. As Grey-Garcia said, 'it was that whole notion of harnessing the corporate media, and throwing it back in their face'.

Recognising the structural problems with commercial media, and experiencing the local shut out of their views, Poor News (as our other anti-poverty groups) has become involved in the larger media democracy movement. This 'movement of movements' seeks to change media practices by engaging with and changing national and international media and information policies, as well as by creating and supporting alternative media structures (Hackett and Carroll 2006; Stein *et al.* forthcoming). As part of this policy focus, in April 2008, Gloria Esteva, a Poor News staff writer and member of Voces de Inmigrantes en Resistencia, spoke at the Federal Communications Commission Hearing on Internet Network Management at Stanford University. Her intervention, part of which is quoted at the beginning of this article, and those of other Poor News journalists, underscored the importance of representing the expert knowledge of low-income and poor people in any process of planning for new information and communications infrastructure.

The future of anti-poverty communications and media

These anti-poverty groups face great challenges and obstacles. Corporate media consolidation and restructuring has resulted in a lack of attention to local community politics, affecting

especially the representation and voice of poor people in the dominant sphere. At the same time, US social policies have shifted the emphasis from national entitlement to workfare pro grammes, reframing poverty as individual failure, and further marginalising the growing number of poor people. In this context, anti-poverty groups like the ones we have studied have had to become much more defensive. Nonetheless, they continue to work to create spaces for poor and homeless people to come together and create dignified identities and to articulate their rights as citizens.

In addition to trying to wedge space in the existing and increasingly closed commercial media, these groups have turned their attention to producing their own media where narratives and frames for poverty are very different. They have trained poor and homeless people as media scholars and producers to represent themselves in commercial and alternative media, and they often go on to create their own media. These autonomous communications spheres foster recognition, including both the individual self-recognition of participants and the collective struggle of this emerging social movement (Williams 2000: 346). Importantly, they also include conventional modes of rational discourse alongside other expressive genres such as poetry, performance, and photography.

This infrastructural work creating *counter-public spheres* not only has an empowerment effect for those immediately involved, it can also affect the representation and power of poor people in the dominant public sphere. For example, the campaigns by Coalition on Homelessness and Poor News Network to reframe poor and homeless people as individuals with rights and expertise, have impacted public policies and perceptions in the city of San Francisco, stopping legislation criminalising the use of shopping carts, and undermining the general legitimacy of 'quality of life' convictions, many of which are routinely dismissed. As part of larger coalitions, the groups have also held back several new laws and regulations aimed at further reducing public support of social, health, educational, and housing programmes. In all of their work, these groups have combined representational strategies, which recognise a plurality of different lived experiences, with the overall intent of challenging the inequities of material distribution for everyone, regardless of income, race/ethnicity, gender, or national status. While the scope of most of their work is local, each of the organisations also links with national and international initiatives, sharing lessons about housing and other social-welfare policies, which are increasingly decided at the national and international levels.

The communications activities of these and other grassroots groups in the Bay Area have widened the public conversation around homelessness and poverty. At a time when the dominant media are abandoning their public responsibilities, these grassroots groups are trying to create public visibility and voice in other ways. It remains to be seen, of course, whether these under-resourced voices will be able to sustain themselves and continue to communicate by and for poor people. However, it is critical that, even as we recognise the deficits caused by the retreat of commercial media from communities, we also recognise the creative struggle that is going on in these communities to create their own public spheres and public voices.

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The authors

Dorothy Kidd (corresponding author) is an Associate Professor of Media Studies at the University of San Francisco. A long-time community media producer, and media policy advocate, she currently volunteers with Media Alliance. Her research interests include the historical development of autonomous media, social justice movements, and social-change communications. Most recently, she co-edited *Making our Media: Global Initiatives Toward a Democratic Public Sphere.* Contact details: Department of Media Studies, University of San Francisco, 2130 Fulton St, San Francisco, CA 94117-1080, USA. <kiddd@usfca.edu>

Bernadette Barker-Plummer is an Associate Professor of Media Studies at the University of San Francisco. Her research interests are in media, social movements, and social change. Some of her work can be found in *Critical Studies in Mass Communication, Journalism Quarterly, Feminist Media Studies,* and *Peace Review.* Contact details: Department of Media Studies, University of San Francisco, 2130 Fulton St, San Francisco, CA 94117-1080, USA.